European Union :

The European Union (EU) is an economic and political union of 28 member countries for their welfare. It has own flag and the common currency, the Euro (€).

Fact :

The Netherlands : About 25 percent of the Netherlands lies below sea level. So they have built dikes. They have reclaimed new land from the sea with the help of dikes. These reclaimed lands are called polders.



Physical Divisions

Europe has diversified physical features such as mountains, plains, plateaus, peninsulas, bays, islands and river basins. It can be divided into four physical divisions.

1. **The North Western Highlands**
2. **The Central Plateaus / High land**
3. **The Alpine Mountain system**
4. **The North European plains**

1. The North Western highlands

This region includes the mountains and plateaus of Norway, Sweden, Finland, Scotland and Iceland. This region has the most beautiful **fiord coast**. It was created by glaciations in the past. This region has a lot of lakes, which serve as reservoirs for producing hydroelectricity. Norway and Sweden are the largest producers of hydroelectricity in the world.

Fact :

Fiord : A fjord is a narrow and deep sea inlet between steep cliffs. It helps in the following ways.

1. It reduces the speed of wind, irrespective of its direction.
2. The force of sea waves are also controlled.

Hence, areas with fiords are best suited for natural harbours.



Fiord coast in Norway

2. The Central Plateaus

The plateaus are found in east west direction across central Europe. Many rivers in Europe such as, the Danube, the Volga and the Tagus originate from this plateau. The important plateaus of this region are The **Pennines** (England), The **Meseta** (Spain), **The Central Massif** and **Jura** (France). The **Black forest** (Germany) in these region has rich mineral resources. The **Pennines** is called the **backbone of England**.

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